Revitalizing, Maintaining, & Sunsetting the Digital Humanities: Strategies & Opportunities

Collins, Perry
pcollins@neh.gov
Independent Scholar

Fenlon, Katrina
kfenlon@umd.edu
University of Maryland–College Park

Langmead, Alison
adlangmead@pitt.edu
University of Pittsburgh

Oates, George
glo@flickr.org
Flickr Foundation

Otis, Jessica
jotis2@gmu.edu
George Mason University

Engagement with technology has transformed the circulation of knowledge in the humanities, granting access to media-rich publications, interactive visualizations, reference databases, and analytical software. Today, many resources developed ten, twenty, or even thirty years ago have become fixtures in the classroom and critical tools for scholarly inquiry. Some of these are well-supported to continue into the future, while others are in danger of being lost to outdated technology and limited engagement with new audiences.

The field increasingly calls for support of existing infrastructure in danger of obsolescence, even as funding opportunities have dwindled amid catastrophic disruption to public funding in the US. “While digital technologies are all too new to know if any DH projects will last for centuries,” writes historian Jessica Otis (2023a), “right now most are struggling to even last years, much less decades. In stark contrast to books, digital projects are generally centralized to one copy, and they decay if they are not actively maintained.” While increasing attention has been paid to digital sustainability in the past decade, including the development of resources such as the Socio-Technical Sustainability Roadmap (Langmead, 2018) or the Endings Project (ongoing), the decay and disappearance of digital projects remains an ongoing problem in the digital humanities (Meneses & Furuta, 2019) and on the internet more broadly (Zittrain, 2021). Attention to sustainability often emphasizes technical development, but equally important are aspects of community engagement, business, governance, and climate impact that directly affect the success or failure of digital projects.

This panel offers multiple perspectives on sustainability from the humanities, information science, cultural heritage, and the funding ecosystem. While much of the work under discussion has developed within a university environment, panelists also consider efforts outside the academy—from community groups, individuals, and even commercial entities—to not only create but also to sustain the digital humanities and its underlying data. Panelists also cast a wide net in their consideration of the scope of digital humanities projects, including interpretive thematic research collections and multimodal publications alongside collections of digitized and born-digital materials and the supporting infrastructure that ensures continuity of access. Taken together, the presentations address a key overarching question: In a time of uncertainty and precarity, how might we strengthen and grow active projects even as we preserve the most valuable components of retired or defunct work?

After an introduction from the panel chair and short presentations from each panelist, a moderated discussion will follow to address common themes, points of debate, and possibilities for the future. Attendees will be encouraged to join in this conversation to share their questions and experiences.

Chair and Moderator: Perry Collins, Independent Scholar

Jessica Otis, Roy Rosenzweig Center for History and New Media, George Mason University

It is a truism of the internet that once a thing is online, it'll be online forever. . . unless you want it to stay up forever, in which case it will soon

be lost. Digital humanities projects that have been put online disappear for a variety of reasons ranging from the social to the financial to the infrastructural (Holmes et al., 2023). Digital humanities centers have especially had to grapple with how to manage their often large digital "backlist" of previous projects, while continuing to make resources available for future work (Otis, 2023b; Smithies et al., 2019).

This talk will examine the ongoing digital sustainability efforts of the Roy Rosenzweig Center for History and New Media (RRCHNM), which was founded in 1994 and continues to sustain hundreds of projects dating back to the late 1990s and early 2000s as well as more recent works. It will take a bird's eye view of the sustainability issues faced by the center over recent years, from orphaned projects and documentation fails to shifting tech stacks and project revitalizations, but ground these discussions in real case studies of specific projects such as the 9/11 Digital Archive (https://911digitalarchive.org), World History Commons (https://worldhistorycommons.org), and the Amboyna Conspiracy Trial (https://amboyna.org). In particular, it will discuss the myriad ways in which the team at RRCHNM is working to "future-proof" existing digital projects—to minimize the social and technical burdens of sustaining past projects while also maximizing the future lifespan and utility of those projects. It will also analyze the sustainability criteria developed by the center and the gap between the ideal form of those processes and workflows, and the reality of how sustainability at a large scale and with a complex creation history works in practice.

Katrina Fenlon, University of Maryland College of Information

Libraries, archives, and museums—traditional institutional stewards of cultural knowledge and published scholarship—have struggled to provide widespread commitments to the endurance and preservation of digital humanities projects. Often maintained by small teams or communities, digital humanities projects tend to function as community-based infrastructures for invaluable cultural knowledge. Sustaining Digital Community Collections is a research project to develop community-centered approaches to ensuring long-lived and thriving digital collections and scholarship. The first phase of this research developed case studies of digital humanities projects, to understand what sustainability means and how stakeholder communities contribute to sustainability outside of the auspices of institutions. The second phase of this research is a systematic review of community-institutional partnerships focused on digital cultural heritage. We survey the diverse and growing landscape of partnerships among communities and cultural institutions in the United States over the past five years, to understand how those partnerships support digital humanities sustainability in a wide range of public and academic contexts. The goals of this research are to identify gaps in our knowledge and practice within stewardship institutions, and to identify alternative approaches to community-centered sustainability for digital humanities.

George Oates, Flickr Foundation

Over the last 20 years, Flickr.com has grown into one of the biggest visual culture collections humans have ever assembled. That deserves special treatment. The Flickr Foundation, formed in 2022, has been established with the purpose of keeping Flickr pictures visible for 100 years. By developing and sustaining an accessible social and technical infrastructure, the Foundation aims to protect this invaluable collection for future generations. One of the Foundation's strategies to achieve this is called Data Lifeboat, which is essentially a proposal to decentralize slivers of this huge collection, for deposit in archives around the world. Joining technical experts and designers with advisors from institutions such as the British Library and Library of Congress, the Data Lifeboat initiative recently undertook an NEH-funded prototype phase. This presentation will share progress on the work so far, especially regarding software and policy design decisions for making sure this important collection sticks around.

We look forward to reflecting with the panel about how this initiative and creating a Foundation for a tech platform could offer some fresh ideas on approaches and shared responsibilities for digital preservation, and what it's like to design an organization with a 100-year outlook from the outset.

Alison Langmead, Department of History of Art and Architecture & School of Computing

and Information, University of Pittsburgh

Digital humanities project teams can take any number of sustainability actions to ensure the availability of their work over time. They might choose to undertake large refreshes tantamount to a redesign, or embark on smaller, planned actions to keep a project ticking, little by little. These approaches all constitute actions of care and attention towards a cherished object. But what about the moment when the team no longer feels that the project holds sufficient value to be worth their ongoing support? What about the moment when, even if the desire to sustain the work remains, the ability to do so is taken away? What is the process like to stop paying attention to something that had previously been so preciously maintained?

In this presentation, I will discuss strategies for retiring digital projects that focus on narrativizing and preserving (or narrativizing-to-preserve) both the process of creating and maintaining digital humanities resources, their typical ongoing modes of use, and their outputs or outcomes. A key goal will be to produce an artifact that commemorates the history of a digital project in a format that is infrastructural enough that professional stewards can likely maintain them in their normal workflow, one that also facilitates the complete retirement of the original project. These strategies assume that to delete a digital humanities project is more than just a series of keystrokes; it is an intentional, important, and deeply uncomfortable act, highly bound up in the fear of being forgotten.

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